for any local communities and the massive displacement that would take place caused significant tension between the Myanmar authorities and Kachin leadership.

With a new leadership in place in 2011, a campaign against the project intensified. A national debate transpired in part because of the easing of media restrictions by the new regime. During the debate, intense nationalism emerged against the project based on the fact that the Irrawaddy River, a symbol of Myanmar, was to be dammed in the project. This was portrayed as tampering with the national heritage of the country. The fact that China was directly involved only served to further fuel the national intensity. The final point of opposition was on environmental grounds. The opposition was massive and organized, which played into the regime's decision to cancel the project. This move on the part of the government is a significant step in easing tension with the Kachin population.

THE ROHINGYA CONTROVERSY

Myanmar's Muslims are mainly Sunni and constitute four percent of the population. They live mostly in the north of Rakhine state (also known as Arakan along the Bangladesh-Myanmar border). The majority are known as Rohingya, and are considered to be of Bengali origin. (An estimated 250,000 Rohingya from Myanmar live in Bangladesh.) They are denied full citizenship in Myanmar, which has sparked considerable controversy in recent years. The authorities claim that the Rohingya are not one of Myanmar's historic ethnic nationalities. Even if this is the case, the Rohingya have undoubtedly lived in Myanmar for several centuries. Their language is derived from the Bengali and is similar to the Chittagonian dialect. An additional group of Muslims in Myanmar are known as the Arakanese or Burmese Muslims. They speak Rakhine, which is closely related to Burmese.

The human rights situation in the Muslim areas of Myanmar has been a grave concern recently. The Muslim minority was targeted for extreme persecution during the reign of Than Shwe. Most of the Muslim minority population is not granted citizenship, barring them from employment and economic opportunities. Travel is restricted, which causes numerous hardships in areas such as education, health care, and employment. In